GOOGLE | 1POINT3ACRES, PRACHUB | TOPIC 10 OF 42 | CORE 90 CHAPTER TOPIC

Core 90 - Topological sort and cycles

3 questions to study here, each on its own page, with the full interview answer and code

Nothing to skip: every question that fits this topic is covered here

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MEDIUM

How to use

- Questions run from Easy to Medium to Hard, newest last-asked date first inside each level.
- PDFs run from the one with the most questions to the fewest. A question has pages in only one PDF; the others list it as SKIP
- Every page has < Prev | Contents | Next > at the bottom. Tap a title in the Contents to jump to it.
- Select code and press Cmd/Ctrl+C to copy it.

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M	3. Determine whether two nodes are related	PracHub	2026-01-22

STUDY PATH: question 56 of 167 (Core 90)

Priority score 7.0 | Topological sort and cycles | asked 16 days ago | frequency Medium

MEDIUM | IN APP LC 210 | 1Point3Acres | onsite-coding | 1 of 3

Course Scheduling and Dependency Variants

ASKED 2026-10-04 | 16 DAYS AGO | LAST 30 DAYS

STUDY: TALK | NO LEETCODE FREQUENCY | PRIORITY 179/228

ABOUT THIS QUESTION

Topic: Core 90 - Topological sort and cycles

Optimal answer from: your app's interview approach (LeetCode #210)

LeetCode match: LC 210 Course Schedule II

Frequency: Medium | Last asked: 2026-10-04

Original: https://www.1point3acres.com/interview/problems/company/google/course-schedule-dependency-variants

QUESTION

Topological-ordering family. Variants: course ordering with validity checks and a nested-list extension; merging two arrays whose internal order defines precedence (return false on a conflict cycle); and a damaged-node dependency-path variant that minimizes broken nodes on a route.

Course-ordering variant

Work through the course-ordering problem, including validity checks, complexity analysis, and test cases.
Extend the result to a nested-list format. The grouping rule is unspecified; clarify what each inner list represents before implementing the extension.

Damaged-node and path variant

Remove damaged nodes and their downstream effects, then find a valid path.
A follow-up minimizes broken nodes on a required route. Clarify the graph direction, path endpoints, and meaning of broken nodes before choosing an algorithm.

Merge-two-ordered-sequences variant

Input: two integer arrays a and b. The order of elements inside each array is an ordering constraint — a = [1, 3, 5] means 1 must come before 3, and 3 before 5.
Determine whether the two arrays can be merged into one sequence that preserves the relative order of both. Return false if the constraints conflict; otherwise return true (or any valid merged sequence).

QUESTION

EXAMPLES

Merge-two-ordered-sequences

```
a = [1, 2, 3]
b = [2, 4, 5]
-> true   (one valid merged order: [1, 2, 3, 4, 5])

a = [1, 6, 4]
b = [4, 1]
-> false  (a requires 1 -> 6 -> 4, b requires 4 -> 1:
    contradiction)
```

APPROACH

In 20 minutes, implement prerequisite ordering with cycle detection; check isolated courses, independent choices, a chain, and a directed cycle.
In 10 minutes, write an independent result checker for vertex coverage and every prerequisite constraint. Accept different valid orders.
In 10 minutes, list the missing grouping and path-cost rules, and explain which algorithm decisions depend on each answer.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Every 'A must come before B' rule is an edge. A valid ordering exists exactly when the graph has no cycle, and Kahn's algorithm finds one: repeatedly take a vertex with no unmet prerequisites. The two-array merge is the same problem: each adjacent pair inside an array is an edge and equal values are the same vertex; the merge is possible only if the combined graph has no cycle.

Basis: LeetCode 210, Course Schedule II, plus a merge-two-ordered-sequences variant (the same graph in disguise).

BRUTE FORCE

BRUTE FORCE · PSEUDO-CODE

```
def brute(n, rules):
    for order in permutations(range(n)):
        pos = {v: i for i, v in enumerate(order)}
        ok = all(pos[a] < pos[b]
                 for a, b in rules)
        if ok:
            return True
    return False
```

TIME	SPACE
O(V! * E)	O(V)

WHY IT IS SLOW

V! orderings. Kahn's algorithm repeatedly takes a vertex with no unmet prerequisites and finishes in O(V + E).

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Kahn's algorithm (course order, or can two sequences merge)

TIME	SPACE
O(V + E)	O(V + E)

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

FOLLOW-UP 1 How do you check that an order is valid?

Record each vertex's position in the order, check that every vertex appears exactly once, then check that for every edge (u, v) the position of u is smaller than the position of v. Accept any valid order, not one fixed answer, because independent vertices can swap.

FULL INTERVIEW CODE · base question + every follow-up

One program for the whole question: the base answer and every follow-up above, built from small helper functions, with a comment above each step. Type it top to bottom in the interview; the demo at the bottom runs it.

```
# MAIN QUESTION: Course Scheduling and Dependency Variants
#
# Topological-ordering family. Variants: course ordering
# with validity checks and a nested-list extension;
# merging two arrays whose internal order defines
# precedence (return false on a conflict cycle); and a
# damaged-node dependency-path variant that minimizes
# broken nodes on a route. Course-ordering variant Work
# through the course-ordering problem, including validity
# checks, complexity analysis, and test cases. Extend the
# result to a nested-list format. The grouping rule is
# unspecified; clarify what each inner list represents
# before implementing the extension. Damaged-node and path
# variant Remove damaged nodes and their downstream
# effects, then find a valid path. A follow-up minimizes
# broken nodes on a required route. Clarify the graph
# direction, path endpoints, and meaning of broken nodes
# before choosing an algorithm. Merge-two-ordered-
# sequences variant Input: two integer arrays a and b.
#
# FOLLOW-UPS (answered below, in this order):
# 1. How do you check that an order is valid?
#
# INTERVIEW NOTES
# Every 'A must come before B' rule is an edge. A valid
# ordering exists exactly when the graph has no cycle, and
# Kahn's algorithm finds one: repeatedly take a vertex
# with no unmet prerequisites. The two-array merge is the
# same problem: each adjacent pair inside an array is an
# edge and equal values are the same vertex; the merge is
# possible only if the combined graph has no cycle.
#
# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Try every permutation of the
# vertices
# Generate permutations and check every constraint.
# Correct and a good oracle for tiny inputs; factorial
# time is unusable beyond about ten vertices. Time O(V! *
# E). Space O(V).


import itertools
from collections import defaultdict, deque


# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Try every permutation of the
# vertices | time O(V! * E)
def merge_orders_brute(a, b):
    vs = sorted(set(a) | set(b))
    edges = [
        (x[i], x[i + 1])
        for x in (a, b)
        for i in range(len(x) - 1)
    ]
    for perm in itertools.permutations(vs):
        pos = {v: i for i, v in enumerate(perm)}
        if all(pos[u] < pos[v] for u, v in edges):
            return True
    return False


# HELPERS for the base question
def edges_from_sequences(*sequences):
    # each neighbouring pair in a sequence is a rule
    return [(s[i], s[i + 1]) for s in sequences
            for i in range(len(s) - 1)]


def merge_two_orders(a, b):
    # shared values are the same vertex
    edges = edges_from_sequences(a, b)
    # a cycle (conflict) gives None
    return topological_order(set(a) | set(b), edges)


# BASE QUESTION (optimal): Kahn's algorithm (course order,
# or can two sequences merge)
# Idea: Build the graph (prerequisite -> dependent,
# including isolated vertices), count indegrees and keep a
# queue of vertices with indegree 0. Pop one, append it to
# the order and lower the indegree of its dependents.
def topological_order(vertices, edges):
    # edge (u, v) means u must come before v
    adj = defaultdict(list)
    indeg = {v: 0 for v in vertices}
    for u, v in edges:
        adj[u].append(v)
        # count unmet prerequisites of v
        indeg[v] = indeg.get(v, 0) + 1
        indeg.setdefault(u, 0)
    # start with everything that has no prerequisite
    queue = deque(v for v, d in indeg.items() if d == 0)
    order = []
    while queue:
        u = queue.popleft()
        order.append(u)
        # finishing u frees its dependents
        for v in adj[u]:
            indeg[v] -= 1
            if indeg[v] == 0:
                queue.append(v)
    # fewer than all vertices means a cycle: no order
    return order if len(order) == len(indeg) else None


# BASE QUESTION (optimal): Kahn's algorithm (course order,
# or can two sequences merge)
# Idea: Build the graph (prerequisite -> dependent,
# including isolated vertices), count indegrees and keep a
# queue of vertices with indegree 0. Pop one, append it to
# the order and lower the indegree of its dependents.
def can_merge(a, b):
    # True when some order keeps both sequences in order
    return merge_two_orders(a, b) is not None


# FOLLOW-UP 1: How do you check that an order is valid?
# Answer: Record each vertex's position in the order,
# check that every vertex appears exactly once, then check
```

```
# that for every edge (u, v) the position of u is smaller
# than the position of v.
def is_valid_order(order, vertices, edges):
    # every vertex must appear exactly once
    if len(order) != len(set(vertices)):
        return False
    if set(order) != set(vertices):
        return False
    pos = {v: i for i, v in enumerate(order)}
    # every prerequisite must come before its dependent
    return all(pos[u] < pos[v] for u, v in edges)


if __name__ == "__main__":
    # course order with an isolated course 3
    courses, rules = range(4), [(0, 1), (1, 2)]
    order = topological_order(courses, rules)
```

```
    assert is_valid_order(order, courses, rules)
    # a swapped order breaks a rule
    swapped = [1, 0, 2, 3]
    assert not is_valid_order(swapped, courses, rules)
    # a cycle has no order
    loop = [(0, 1), (1, 0)]
    assert topological_order(range(2), loop) is None
    # merge examples from the question
    assert can_merge([1, 2, 3], [2, 4, 5])
    merged = merge_two_orders([1, 2, 3], [2, 4, 5])
    assert merged is not None
    assert not can_merge([1, 6, 4], [4, 1])
    # a repeated value in one array is a self conflict
    assert not can_merge([1, 2, 1], [])
```

NOTES FROM CANDIDATES

For standard prerequisite-ordering practice, represent each course as a vertex and each prerequisite as an edge from prerequisite to dependent. Include isolated courses. The result orders every course after its prerequisites; a cycle prevents a complete ordering.

Maintain indegrees and a queue of zero-indegree vertices. Emit a vertex, decrement its outgoing neighbors, and enqueue newly ready vertices. If fewer than V vertices are emitted, report failure under the chosen return convention. This takes O(V + E) time and space; check each edge against positions in the output to validate an ordering.

This ordering algorithm does not determine the nested-list grouping rule or solve the damaged-node path objective. Keep those contracts separate rather than assuming they are ordinary topological sorting.

The merge-two-sequences variant is the same ordering engine in disguise: shared values are the same node, and each adjacent pair inside an array is an edge. A cycle means the merge is impossible. It was asked as the final onsite round of an early-career L3 loop, and the candidate nearly ran out of time — recognizing it as a graph problem early is the main hurdle.

PREPARATION

In 20 minutes, implement prerequisite ordering with cycle detection; check isolated courses, independent choices, a chain, and a directed cycle.
In 10 minutes, write an independent result checker for vertex coverage and every prerequisite constraint. Accept different valid orders.
In 10 minutes, list the missing grouping and path-cost rules, and explain which algorithm decisions depend on each answer.

STUDY PATH: question 57 of 167 (Core 90)

Priority score 6.0 | Topological sort and cycles | asked 3 days ago | frequency Low

MEDIUM | 1Point3Acres | onsite-coding | 2 of 3

Template Variable Expansion with Follow-Ups

ASKED 2026-10-17 | 3 DAYS AGO | LAST 30 DAYS

STUDY: READ **NO LEETCODE FREQUENCY** **PRIORITY 214/228**

ABOUT THIS QUESTION

Topic: Core 90 - Topological sort and cycles

Optimal answer from: written and tested here for this exact question

Frequency: Low | Last asked: 2026-10-17 | Roles: SWE

Original: https://www.1point3acres.com/interview/problems/company/google/template-variable-expansion-dependencies

QUESTION

Replace **%KEY%** placeholders using a key-value map whose values may contain other placeholders. Clarify malformed delimiters and literal-percent escaping, flatten nested values, and detect cyclic dependencies before expansion.

Input: a key-value map and a string containing placeholders delimited by %, such as %USER%. Replace every placeholder with the corresponding value.
Map values can themselves contain placeholders, so resolve or flatten dependencies before expanding the final string.
Define behavior for malformed delimiters such as unmatched percent signs, for a literal % in output, and for nested-looking forms before coding; the prompt intentionally leaves these contracts open.
Follow-up: detect cyclic dependencies among map values.
Model keys as a dependency graph and use indegrees plus a queue to determine whether a complete topological resolution is possible.

EXAMPLES

```
Given {USER: "admin", HOME: "/%USER%/home"}:
```

Input: I am %USER% My home is %HOME% Output: I am admin My home is /admin/home

APPROACH

Implement one-pass placeholder scanning under a written delimiter/escape contract.
Resolve a dependency chain in the map before processing the template, then add cycle detection.
Prepare three malformed-input cases and explain whether each is rejected, preserved literally, or interpreted as an escape.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Agree the grammar first: %NAME% is a placeholder, %% is a literal percent sign, an unmatched % is an error and an unknown name is an error. Values may contain placeholders themselves, so expand a value by expanding its own placeholders first. A cycle (A uses B, B uses A) would recurse forever, so detect it with a visiting set or, equivalently, with indegrees and a queue.

Basis: Written for this question; resolving values that contain other placeholders is a dependency graph problem (as in LeetCode 210, Course Schedule II).

BRUTE FORCE

BRUTE FORCE · PSEUDO-CODE

```
def expand(text, depth=0):
    if depth > LIMIT:
        raise Error("too deep: cycle?")
    out = ""
    for token in tokens(text):
        if token == "%%":
            out += "%"
        elif is_key(token):
            value = values[name_of(token)]
            out += expand(value, depth + 1)
        else:
            out += token
    return out
```

TIME	SPACE
exponential in the worst ... exponential in the worst case	**O(depth)**

WHY IT IS SLOW

Re-expands shared values every time and finds cycles only by running out of depth. Memoising each value and keeping a visiting set expands each key once and reports a cycle at once.

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Depth-first expansion with memo and a visiting set

TIME	SPACE
O(total length of the expanded text + keys)	**O(keys)**

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

FOLLOW-UP 1 Detect cycles before expanding.

Model each key as a vertex with an edge to every key its value mentions, count indegrees and run Kahn's algorithm: if fewer vertices than keys come out, some keys sit on a cycle and cannot be resolved. This reports the problem up front instead of failing halfway through a long document.

FULL INTERVIEW CODE · base question + every follow-up

One program for the whole question: the base answer and every follow-up above, built from small helper functions, with a comment above each step. Type it top to bottom in the interview; the demo at the bottom runs it.

```
# MAIN QUESTION: Template Variable Expansion with Follow-
# Ups
#
# Replace %KEY% placeholders using a key-value map whose
# values may contain other placeholders. Clarify malformed
# delimiters and literal-percent escaping, flatten nested
# values, and detect cyclic dependencies before expansion.
# Input: a key-value map and a string containing
# placeholders delimited by %, such as %USER%. Replace
# every placeholder with the corresponding value. Map
# values can themselves contain placeholders, so resolve
# or flatten dependencies before expanding the final
# string. Define behavior for malformed delimiters such as
# unmatched percent signs, for a literal % in output, and
# for nested-looking forms before coding; the prompt
# intentionally leaves these contracts open. Follow-up:
# detect cyclic dependencies among map values. Model keys
# as a dependency graph and use indegrees plus a queue to
# determine whether a complete topological resolution is
# possible.
#
# FOLLOW-UPS (answered below, in this order):
# 1. Detect cycles before expanding.
#
# INTERVIEW NOTES
# Agree the grammar first: %NAME% is a placeholder, %% is
# a literal percent sign, an unmatched % is an error and
# an unknown name is an error. Values may contain
# placeholders themselves, so expand a value by expanding
# its own placeholders first. A cycle (A uses B, B uses A)
# would recurse forever, so detect it with a visiting set
# or, equivalently, with indegrees and a queue.
#
# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Recursive expansion without
# memo or cycle check, capped by depth
# Recursively substitute placeholders and stop with an
# error after a fixed depth. Correct for acyclic maps;
# repeats shared work and detects cycles only by running
# out of depth. Time exponential in the worst case. Space
# O(depth).


from collections import defaultdict, deque
```

```
# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Recursive expansion without
# memo or cycle check, capped by depth | time exponential
# in the worst case
def expand_brute(text, mapping, depth=0):
    if depth > 30:
        raise ValueError("cycle")
    out, i = [], 0
    while i < len(text):
        if text[i] != "%":
            out.append(text[i])
            i += 1
        elif text[i : i + 2] == "%%":
            out.append("%")
            i += 2
        else:
            j = text.find("%", i + 1)
            if j < 0:
                raise ValueError("unmatched %")
            out.append(
                expand_brute(
                    mapping[text[i + 1 : j]],
                    mapping,
                    depth + 1,
                )
            )
            i = j + 1
    return "".join(out)


# HELPERS for the base question
def tokens(s):
    # split text into ("text", char) and ("var", name)
    i = 0
    while i < len(s):
        if s[i] != "%":
            yield "text", s[i]
            i += 1
        elif s[i:i + 2] == "%%":
            # %% is a literal percent sign
            yield "text", "%"
            i += 2
        else:
            j = s.find("%", i + 1)
            if j < 0:
                raise ValueError("unmatched %")
            yield "var", s[i + 1:j]
            i = j + 1


# BASE QUESTION (optimal): Depth-first expansion with memo
# and a visiting set
# Idea: expand(text) scans the text once: %% becomes %,
# %NAME% becomes the resolved value of NAME.
def expand_template(text, mapping):
    done, visiting = {}, set()

    def resolve(name):
        # values may hold placeholders: expand them first
        if name in done:
            return done[name]
        if name in visiting:
            raise ValueError("cycle at " + name)
        if name not in mapping:
            raise KeyError(name)
        visiting.add(name)
        done[name] = scan(mapping[name])
        visiting.discard(name)
        return done[name]

    def scan(s):
        return "".join(resolve(x) if kind == "var" else x
                       for kind, x in tokens(s))

    return scan(text)


# FOLLOW-UP 1: Detect cycles before expanding.
# Answer: Model each key as a vertex with an edge to every
# key its value mentions, count indegrees and run Kahn's
# algorithm: if fewer vertices than keys come out, some
# keys sit on a cycle and cannot be resolved.
def has_cycle(mapping):
    # Kahn's algorithm over key -> keys it mentions
    deps = {}
    for k, v in mapping.items():
        deps[k] = {x for kind, x in tokens(v)
                   if kind == "var"}
    users, indeg = defaultdict(list), {}
    for k, d in deps.items():
        known = d & mapping.keys()
        indeg[k] = len(known)
        for x in known:
```

```
            users[x].append(k)
    queue = deque(k for k, n in indeg.items() if n == 0)
    resolved = 0
    while queue:
        k = queue.popleft()
        resolved += 1
        for u in users[k]:
            indeg[u] -= 1
            if indeg[u] == 0:
                queue.append(u)
    # keys left over sit on a cycle
    return resolved != len(mapping)


if __name__ == "__main__":
    m = {"USER": "admin", "HOME": "/%USER%/home"}
    text = "I am %USER% My home is %HOME%"
    assert expand_template(text, m) == (
        "I am admin My home is /admin/home")
    sure = expand_template("100%% sure", {})
    assert sure == "100% sure"
    assert not has_cycle(m)
    loop = {"A": "%B%", "B": "%A%"}
    assert has_cycle(loop)
    for bad, error in (("a % b", ValueError),
                       ("%NOPE%", KeyError)):
        try:
            expand_template(bad, {})
            raise AssertionError("should have failed")
        except error:
            pass
    try:
        expand_template("%A%", loop)
        raise AssertionError("cycle not caught")
    except ValueError:
        pass
```

NOTES FROM CANDIDATES

The interviewer spent most of the round probing the delimiter and escaping contract before allowing implementation. State a compact grammar and get explicit agreement; otherwise a nominally easy parser can lose the coding budget to unresolved edge cases.

PREPARATION

Implement one-pass placeholder scanning under a written delimiter/escape contract.
Resolve a dependency chain in the map before processing the template, then add cycle detection.
Prepare three malformed-input cases and explain whether each is rejected, preserved literally, or interpreted as an escape.

STUDY PATH: question 58 of 167 (Core 90)

Priority score 1.98 | Topological sort and cycles | asked 271 days ago

MEDIUM | PracHub | Technical Screen | 3 of 3

Determine whether two nodes are related

POSTED 2026-01-22 | 271 DAYS AGO | OLDER

STUDY: TALK | ALL TIME 24.5 | 30 DAYS 0 | PRIORITY 142/228

ABOUT THIS QUESTION

Topic: Core 90 - Topological sort and cycles

Optimal answer from: the interview site's own solution

LeetCode match: LC 1971 Find if Path Exists in Graph (inferred from overview)

Posted on PracHub: 2026-01-22 (updated 2026-06-26)

Original: https://prachub.com/coding-questions/determine-whether-two-nodes-are-related

QUESTION

Overview: This question evaluates understanding of graph representations, reachability and connectivity concepts for ancestry relationships, including handling disconnected components and potential cycles.

APPROACH

Build the ancestry graph and BFS/DFS (or union-find for undirected relatedness); handle disconnected components.

INTERVIEW-DAY PLAN

CLARIFY FIRST

Ask what related means: one is an ancestor of the other, they share a common ancestor, or they are connected in any direction. Ask whether the graph is a tree, a DAG, or may have cycles, and whether it is disconnected.

BRUTE FORCE TO SAY OUT LOUD

DFS from the first node looking for the second, and again from the second. O(V + E) per query.

OPTIMAL IDEA

Build the adjacency list once. For ancestry in a DAG compute the ancestor set of each node (DFS or BFS) and test for the target or a non-empty intersection. For undirected relatedness use union-find, which answers queries in near constant time after one pass. Track visited to survive cycles.

DRY-RUN THESE CASES

A node related to itself, two nodes in separate components, a long chain, a cycle.

LIKELY FOLLOW-UPS

Many queries (precompute components or ancestors), the lowest common ancestor, or updates to the graph.

PITFALLS

Missing a visited set. Treating direction as undirected, or the reverse.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Ask what 'related' means: connected in any direction (a connectivity question: union-find or one traversal), or ancestor/descendant, or share an ancestor. With many queries, preprocess once: components give O(1) answers. Always make the visited set part of the design, since relationship data can have cycles.

Basis: LeetCode 1971, Find if Path Exists in Graph, for connectivity, and ancestor queries on a parent map for the 'ancestry' reading. Assumed meaning (confirm it): related = connected by any path of relationships.

BRUTE FORCE

BRUTE FORCE · PSEUDO-CODE

```
def related(a, b):
    graph = build_adjacency(edges)
    seen = set()
    dfs(graph, a, seen)
    return b in seen
```

TIME	SPACE
O(V + E) per query	O(V)

WHY IT IS SLOW

Every query repeats the same traversal, O(V + E) each. A Union-Find built once answers each query in near-constant time.

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Union-Find built once, constant-time queries

TIME	SPACE
O(E alpha(V)) to build, O(alpha(V)) per query	O(V)

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

FOLLOW-UP 1 'Related' means ancestor or descendant, or sharing an ancestor.

Store the data as a parent map and walk up from one node while recording ancestors, then walk up from the other until you hit one. Keep a seen set so a corrupt cycle cannot loop forever.

FOLLOW-UP 2 Relationships arrive over time and you must answer queries between updates.

Union-Find handles incremental unions in near-constant time. If relationships can also be removed, you need offline processing or a dynamic-connectivity structure.

FOLLOW-UP 3 The graph is directed and 'related' means reachability from a to b.

Union-Find no longer works (it ignores direction). Use DFS/BFS per query, or compute strongly connected components and reachability on the condensed DAG for many queries.

FULL INTERVIEW CODE · base question + every follow-up

One program for the whole question: the base answer and every follow-up above, built from small helper functions, with a comment above each step. Type it top to bottom in the interview; the demo at the bottom runs it.

```
# MAIN QUESTION: Determine whether two nodes are related
#
# This question evaluates understanding of graph
# representations, reachability and connectivity concepts
# for ancestry relationships, including handling
# disconnected components and potential cycles.
#
# FOLLOW-UPS (answered below, in this order):
# 1. 'Related' means ancestor or descendant, or sharing an
# ancestor.
# 2. Relationships arrive over time and you must answer
# queries between updates.
# 3. The graph is directed and 'related' means
# reachability from a to b.
#
# INTERVIEW NOTES
# Ask what 'related' means: connected in any direction (a
# connectivity question: union-find or one traversal), or
# ancestor/descendant, or share an ancestor. With many
# queries, preprocess once: components give O(1) answers.
# Always make the visited set part of the design, since
# relationship data can have cycles.
#
# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Search from the first node
# for every query
# Build adjacency lists and run a DFS from a looking for b
# each time. Correct, and each query repeats the same
# traversal work. Time O(V + E) per query. Space O(V).


from collections import defaultdict
from collections import deque


# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Search from the first node
# for every query | time O(V + E) per query
def related_dfs(n, edges, a, b):
    adj = defaultdict(list)
    for u, v in edges:
        adj[u].append(v)
        adj[v].append(u)
    seen, stack = {a}, [a]
    while stack:
        x = stack.pop()
        if x == b:
            return True
        for y in adj[x]:
            if y not in seen:
                seen.add(y)
                stack.append(y)
    return False


# BASE QUESTION (optimal): Union-Find built once,
# constant-time queries
# Idea: Union the endpoints of every relationship; two
# nodes are related exactly when they have the same root.
class Relations:
    """Related = joined by a chain of relations."""

    def __init__(self, n, edges=()):
        self.parent = list(range(n))
        self.size = [1] * n
        for u, v in edges:
            self.union(u, v)

    def find(self, x):
        while self.parent[x] != x:
            self.parent[x] = self.parent[self.parent[x]]
            x = self.parent[x]
        return x

    def union(self, a, b):
        # relations can arrive over time: near-constant
        # time
        ra, rb = self.find(a), self.find(b)
        if ra == rb:
            return
        # the smaller group joins the bigger one
        if self.size[ra] < self.size[rb]:
            ra, rb = rb, ra
        self.parent[rb] = ra
        self.size[ra] += self.size[rb]

    def related(self, a, b):
        return self.find(a) == self.find(b)


# HELPER: ancestors of a node
def ancestors(parent, x):
    # x and everything above it; a seen set stops cycles
    seen = []
    while x is not None and x not in seen:
        seen.append(x)
        x = parent.get(x)
    return seen


# FOLLOW-UP 1: 'Related' means ancestor or descendant, or
# sharing an ancestor.
# Answer: Store the data as a parent map and walk up from
# one node while recording ancestors, then walk up from
# the other until you hit one. Keep a seen set so a
# corrupt cycle cannot loop forever.
def kin(parent, a, b):
    # related if one is an ancestor of the other, or they
    # share an ancestor
    up_a = ancestors(parent, a)
    up_b = ancestors(parent, b)
    return bool(set(up_a) & set(up_b))


# FOLLOW-UP 3: The graph is directed and 'related' means
# reachability from a to b.
# Answer: Union-Find no longer works (it ignores
# direction). Use DFS/BFS per query, or compute strongly
# connected components and reachability on the condensed
# DAG for many queries.
```

```
def reachable(graph, a, b):
    # directed: can we get from a to b? (Union-Find cannot
    # tell, it ignores direction)
    seen, queue = {a}, deque([a])
    while queue:
        u = queue.popleft()
        if u == b:
            return True
        for v in graph.get(u, ()):
            if v not in seen:
                seen.add(v)
                queue.append(v)
    return False


if __name__ == "__main__":
    r = Relations(5, [(0, 1), (1, 2)])
```

```
    assert r.related(0, 2) and not r.related(0, 3)
    r.union(3, 4)
    assert r.related(3, 4) and not r.related(2, 4)
    r.union(2, 3)
    assert r.related(0, 4)
    assert r.related(1, 1)
    # a family tree: parent[child] = parent
    parent = {"kid": "mom", "mom": "gran",
              "uncle": "gran", "stranger": None}
    assert kin(parent, "kid", "gran")
    assert kin(parent, "kid", "uncle")
    assert not kin(parent, "kid", "stranger")
    # a corrupt cycle cannot loop forever
    assert kin({"a": "b", "b": "a"}, "a", "b")
    # direction matters for reachability
    g = {"a": ["b"], "b": ["c"]}
    assert reachable(g, "a", "c")
    assert not reachable(g, "c", "a")
```

FUNCTION AND TEST CASES

Signature

```
def solution(relations: list[list[int]], a: int, b: int) -
> bool:
```

Sample call

```
solution([(1, 2), (1, 3), (3, 4), (10, 11)], 2, 4)
```

Test cases

Input	Expected
`([(1, 2), (1, 3), (3, 4), (10, 11)], 2, 4)`	`True`
`([(1, 2), (1, 3), (3, 4), (10, 11)], 2, 11)`	`False`